# The Architecture of Carrierless Continuity

*Deconstructing the Metaphysics of Flow: Dependent Designation, Tsongkhapa's Mere I, and the Vivid Instant*

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## Executive Summary

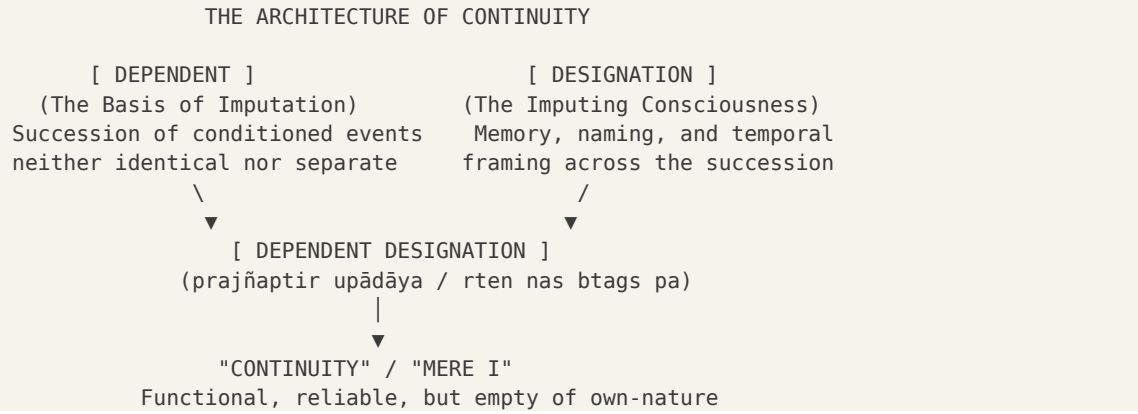
Common sense and classical metaphysics share an unspoken dogma: that **continuity** is an objective baseline woven into the fabric of reality, a mind-independent river that flows whether anyone observes it or not. Under this assumption, continuity requires an *invariant bearer* (a soul, an enduring self, a neural core, or conserved physical energy) to carry identity across time.

Drawing on John Tan's (*Thusness*) treatise *Death and Continuity*, companion texts from *The Logical Necessity of a Substrateless World*, and the Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka dialectic of Nāgārjuna and Je Tsongkhapa, this report establishes three findings:

1. **Continuity is not given; it is designated.** Continuity requires both **dependence** (a conditioned succession) and **designation** (imputation across that succession). Neither alone yields continuity. This union is Tsongkhapa's doctrine of the **mere I** (*nga tsam*).
2. **When designation suspends, no continuum appears.** In deep sleep, general anaesthesia, or raw non-conceptual sensory impact, no subterranean thread of time flows in secret, and none is found under analysis. Yet the continuity is not erased from conventional existence: the clock, the surgeon and, on waking, the patient herself validly designate the three hours.
3. **Designation realized as empty.** Seeing that continuity is *merely designated* does not annihilate conventional functioning. It strips away the substantialist habit that treats life as a possession and death as its theft. The result is a continuity as open as its conditions allow: promises hold, habits can loosen, and each appearance is met as vivid and unobstructed (*ma 'gags pa*).

## 1. The Twin Pillars: Why Continuity Requires Both "Dependent" and "Designation"

Continuity is not a basic sensory datum. It is designated, and it has two poles; take either away and there is no continuity to speak of.




### 1.1 The "Dependent" (*pratītya / rten nas*)

Continuity cannot be imputed onto thin air. It requires a conditioned succession in which later con figurations arise in dependence on earlier ones.

- A rice sprout arises in dependence on a rice seed, not an acorn.
- The flame at midnight depends on the flame at dusk and on the ongoing burning of oil and oxygen.

Yet the conditionality **carries no traveller**. The seed does not crawl into the sprout; the dusk flame does not ride into the midnight flame. Nothing passes from one to the next.

### 1.2 The "Designation" (*prajñapti / btags pa*)

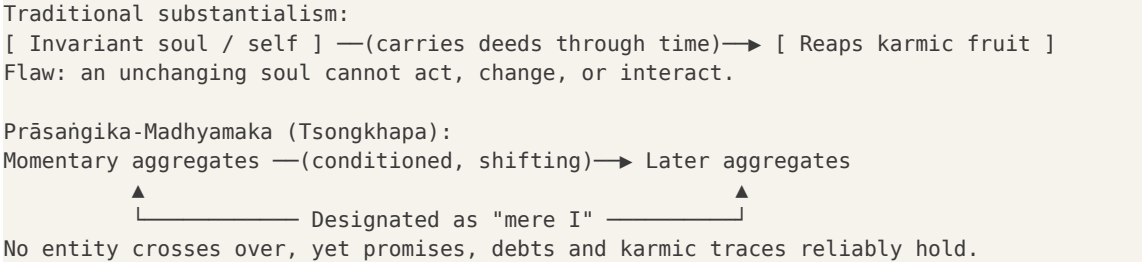
A conditioned succession alone is not yet "continuity". The moments are gathered, a boundary is drawn around them, and they are named *one ongoing event*:

- We designate the burning candle as **"the same flame burning all night."**
- We designate a succession of distinct musical vibrations as **"a melody."**
- We designate the child, the adolescent and the ageing adult as **"the same person."**

**The critical insight:** continuity is not a pre-existing wire that the label merely wraps. **The designation is the continuity**, not a cover over a hidden flow. Take away the designation, and the "continuum" does not remain as an objective fact standing by itself. Nor does it lapse into non-existence. Conventional existence is established by convention, by what is suitable to be known, not by any one mind's present act of naming.

## 2. Je Tsongkhapa's "Mere I" (*nga tsam*)

This resolves the old riddle of personal identity and karma without positing an eternal soul (*ātman*) and without falling into moral nihilism (*ucchedavāda*).



### 2.1 Identity Without an Invariant Bearer

Classical philosophies assumed that for someone to be responsible for a promise made twenty years ago, an invariant core must have survived the interval.

Following Candrakīrti and Nāgārjuna, Tsongkhapa holds that the self is neither identical to the aggregates (*skandhas*) nor separate from them:

- The self is the **mere I** (*nga tsam*): an agent designated in dependence on a stream of changing physical and mental aggregates.
- The child in a photograph is not identical to you today, nor an unrelated stranger.
- The word "I" reliably links those stages across decades. The mere I keeps its word, repays its debts and experiences the ripening of past actions, **while being unfindable under ultimate analysis**.

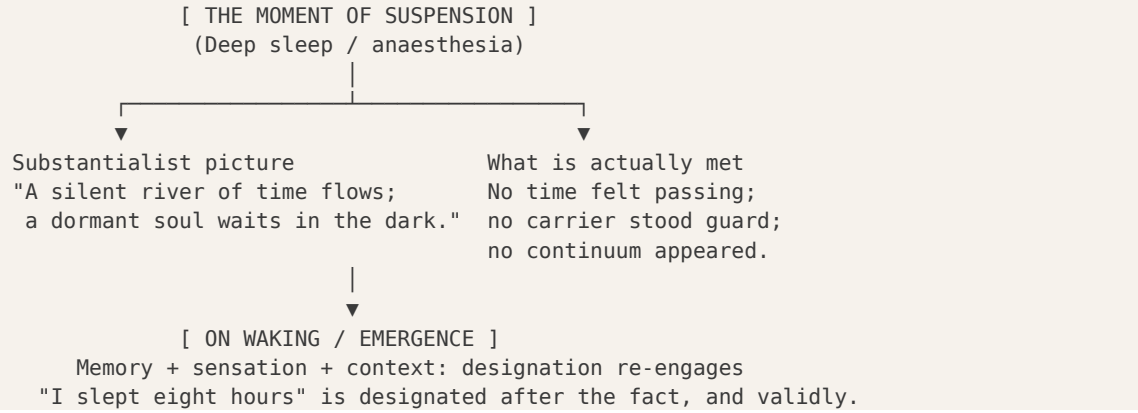
### 2.2 Continuity Is a Functional Treaty, Not a Substance

The mere I has no independent substance. It exists as a designation that functions within conventional transactions (*vyavahāra*). Its continuity is real and reliable in the way a treaty or a currency is real: it coordinates action and bears consequences, yet no ounce of substance called "a dollar" or "the self" can be extracted from it.

## 3. The Provocation: What Happens When No One Is Designating?

To loosen the instinctive belief that continuity is an objective, self-standing background, ask:

**"If continuity exists from its own side, what happens to it when the capacity to designate is absent?"**




### 3.1 Anaesthesia: No River, No Passenger

Consider general anaesthesia or dreamless sleep:

- Three hours pass on the operating-room clock. For the patient, **no time is felt passing**.
- The substantialist imagines time as a dark river carrying a switched-off spectator, like an unconscious passenger in a boat.
- But look closely at the experience: **no river appeared**. No dark corridor was traversed, no duration endured.
- Where was "continuity" during those three hours? From the standpoint of immediate experience, it did not *appear*. That is not the same as saying it did not exist. The world's

convention (the clock, the surgeon, the hospital record) says she was under for three hours, and Tsongkhapa's three criteria accept it.

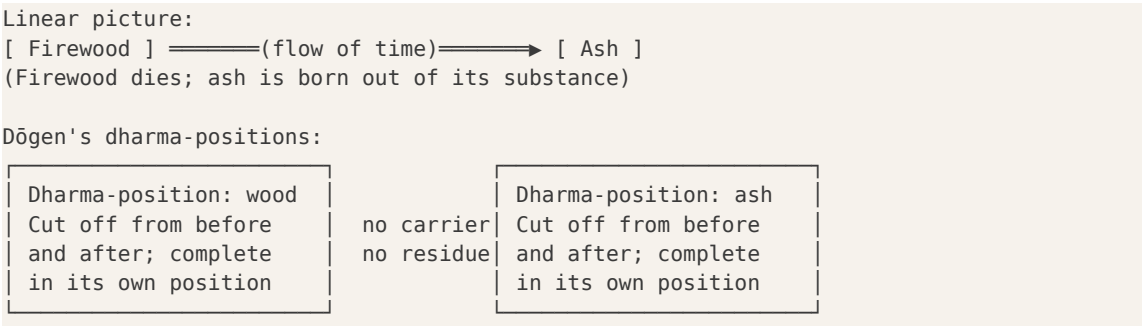
- On waking, memory, the room and the clock come together, and she designates: *"I was asleep for three hours."*

Her own continuity is designated after the fact, but it is not invented after the fact. "A secret persistence" and "a real break" are the two extremes (MMK 15.10). Conventionally the continuity holds. Under analysis it is not found, and neither is the waking patient.

### 3.2 Dōgen's Dharma-Positions: Cut Off, Yet Fully Present

In the *Genjōkōan*, Dōgen undoes the linear picture of flow:

> Firewood becomes ash, and it cannot become firewood again. Yet one should not take the view that ash is after and firewood is before... Firewood abides in the dharma-position of firewood, which has a before and an after and yet is cut off from before and after. Ash abides in the dharma-position of ash, which has a before and an after and yet is cut off from before and after.

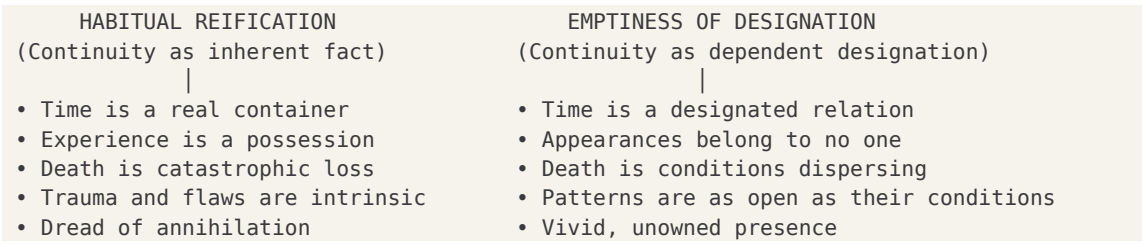



When designation does not string moments along a timeline:

- **Each appearance is complete in its own position.** Winter does not "become" spring; life does not "turn into" death.
- **Seamlessness comes from the absence of residue.** Experience is fluid, not jarring, not because a sticky soul carries sensations from one room to the next, but because **nothing persists** to cause friction. A sound ends cleanly without dragging into the eye; seeing arises freshly on its own conditions.

## 4. Designation Realized as Conventional and Empty

The point is not to suppress designation but to **see what it is**. What changes when designation is recognised as conventional and empty?



### 4.1 The Habit: Why We Suffer

Suffering (*duḥkha*) is rooted in treating a designation as an inherent property of the world.

- We designate "cold" on ice, then imagine the cold resides inside the ice from its own side.
- We designate "self" on the continuum of aggregates, then imagine a real owner standing behind experience who possesses consciousness.
- Because experience is treated as a possession, **death is anticipated as a robbery**: the dread that this vivid afternoon, this room and this sense of being will be taken from the one holding them.

### 4.2 The Realization: Possessor and Possession Dissolve

When continuity is seen as dependently designated:

1. **The possessor is removed.** There never was a central entity holding awareness. Experience happens without a landlord.
2. **The possession is removed.** Appearances are not goods stored in a warehouse. A sound is vivid, ringing and immediately gone; a thought arises and leaves no footprint.
3. **The fear of death loses its object.** Death cannot deprive an owner of experience, because no owner ever possessed it. Death is the dispersal of a particular constellation of conditions: the burning down of a candle whose light was never an owned substance. Nothing is carried, and nothing is cut off; karma and the conditioning of what follows are affirmed conventionally.

### 4.3 Plasticity: The Freedom of Carrierless Continuity

If continuity were grounded in an inherent carrier:

- A traumatic past would be carved into your essence.
- A neurotic pattern or a bitter grievance would be an intrinsic property of who you are.

Because continuity is **designated across dependent conditions**, nothing is anchored to a permanent bedrock:

- A habit can soften.
- A character can renew itself.
- A grievance can end.

This openness is not unlimited. A continuity is exactly as plastic as its conditions allow, and no more. It is more reliable than the nihilist imagines, because conditions function rigorously, and more open than the substantialist can allow.

## 5. Summary Matrix: Three Orders of Understanding

| Dimension | 1. Substantialist ignorance (*avidyā*) | 2. Designation suspended (sleep, anaesthesia) | 3. Designation realized as empty (*prajñapti*) |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Status of continuity** | An objective, mind-independent river carrying things. | No continuum appears to this stream; conventionally it is not erased. Under analysis, none is found in either case. | A valid conventional designation with no substrate beneath it. |
| **Status of the self** | Invariant bearer (*ātman*, permanent soul, neural core). | No sense of self is operating; appearances, if any, belong to no one. | Tsongkhapa's **mere I**: functional, accountable, empty of *svabhāva*. |
| **Interruption (sleep, death)** | Fear of annihilation; dread that the container will break. | No time felt passing; no passenger in the dark. | Free from both eternalism and annihilationism; conditions assemble and disperse. |
| **Psychological stance** | Rigid identification, grasping, essentialised trauma, defensiveness. | Unmediated presence without narrative framing. | Plasticity within conditions, spontaneous responsiveness, responsibility without fixation. |
| **Luminosity** | Mistaken for a cosmic consciousness or an eternal witness. | Not a witness that stays awake in the dark. | The knowing clarity of appearing itself, empty like the appearing; not a nature behind it. |

## Concluding Insight

Continuity was never a given fact awaiting discovery. It is a designation that holds between depend ent conditions, and as a designation it is fully valid.

When no one is designating, no continuum appears and none is found, yet nothing is erased from conventional existence. Only the phantom river was never there. When designation resumes, it is recognised for what it has always been: a flexible, functional convention that makes action, kindness and communication possible, without binding the mind to an illusion of permanence or to the terror of death.